

Portable Single-Mirror Schlieren Apparatus

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Design Description

Revision: Oct 4, 2026

This document describes the design of the apparatus, and is maintained authoritatively as Markdown fragments in the project repo on github at <https://github.com/fritzm/schlieren/tree/main/docs/design>.

Conventions

- The design described here is the baseline. Unless marked otherwise, dimensions, parts, and methods are settled.
- **Provisional** marks a design area, dimension, or method that is still open or evolving, typically pending a physical fit check, measurement, or further design. Provisional areas are rolled up with next steps in §11.
- Measured values, manufacturer specifications, and calculated values are identified as such where the distinction matters; a measured value takes precedence over a catalog value.
- Quantities, vendors, part numbers beyond those needed to define the design, procurement state, and the CAD state of printed parts are recorded in the BOM, `bom/bom.csv`, not here.

1. Project context and design constraints

The apparatus is a portable, single-mirror schlieren system intended initially for several days of vacation/travel use in a location with a large room and a substantial tabletop. It should remain useful afterward as a bench-top laboratory instrument.

The complete system should pack into a standard airline rolling suitcase. Plan around the ordinary 50 lb / 23 kg checked-bag target unless a higher allowance applies.

The design is cost-conscious rather than constrained to a fixed dollar ceiling. Commodity 2020 extrusion, Baltic birch plywood, standard fasteners, and printed ABS are preferred where they are adequate. Commercial optomechanics are used where they materially simplify alignment or provide precision that would otherwise be troublesome.

1.1 Fabrication envelope

Near-term 3D printing is ABS only. Critical optical heights and precision datums should preferably be established by metal posts, optical hardware, shim stock, mechanical stops, or adjustment mechanisms rather than relying solely on as-printed ABS dimensions.

The following are out of scope:

- custom machined parts requiring a mill or lathe;
- cutting stainless-steel stock or sheet to custom shape or length.

Use off-the-shelf metal parts, vendor-supplied finished dimensions, plywood, aluminum that can be drilled/tapped with ordinary shop tools, thin foil, or printed ABS. Simple drilling and tapping of the aluminum LED carrier caps and heatsinks is within scope.

A table saw, drill press, and small hand router are available and are expected to be used for accurate working of Baltic birch plywood panels (thanks, Bret!)

2. System overview and physical layout

The apparatus consists of two main physical assemblies:

1. a tabletop optical head; and
2. a separate mirror cell, normally tripod-mounted approximately 3.2 m away.

The tabletop optical head uses two independently yaw-adjustable 2020 aluminum-extrusion rails mounted to a common Baltic-birch front pivot plate. The rails diverge slightly away from the mirror-facing end so that each rail follows one optical chief ray:

- the source rail carries the illumination system directed toward the mirror;
- the imaging rail carries the cutoff and camera system for the return beam.

The source rail contains, in optical order:

1. interchangeable threaded LED/heatsink source module, screwed into the condenser holder;
2. condenser and adjustable iris;
3. source-slit flexure head.

The slit is the effective optical source. The LED primarily illuminates that slit through the condenser and therefore does not itself require the same precision vertical positioning as the slit.

The imaging rail contains:

1. cutoff carriage at the returned slit-image plane;
2. lens pointer, holding the telephoto lens;
3. phone rest, under the iPhone hanging from the lens.

The spherical mirror forms an image of the source slit back near the optical head. Refractive-index gradients in the test region near the mirror deflect portions of this return beam relative to the cutoff, producing schlieren contrast.

Several source-side and cutoff-side fixtures deliberately share common mechanics. Three locations use a common TR50/M post + printed rail shoe concept:

1. LED/condenser/iris;
2. source-slit flexure head;
3. cutoff carriage.

The source slit and the cutoff both rotate about the optical axis in a Thorlabs SM1RC/M SM1 slip ring. The slit uses a flexure head with fine centering and slit-width adjustment (§7); the cutoff uses a rotating carriage with a 64 mm cassette envelope, allowing knife-edge, wire, and color-filter experiments without changing the supporting mechanism (§8).

The mirror cell uses a three-point, approximately 120°-spaced fine-adjustment architecture with compression springs and spherical washer interfaces. The mirror is compliantly supported in the moving plate by six radial DOWSIL 737 pads between the mirror edge and the inner surface of the plywood aperture.

3. System-level geometry

3.1 Primary optic

- Mirror: Skyoptikst D203F1600
- Diameter: 203 mm

- Focal length: 1600 mm
- Surface: spherical
- Radius of curvature / nominal operating distance: approximately 3200 mm

The source slit and imaging/cutoff system operate near the mirror center of curvature. The test region is near the mirror, where outgoing and returning beams remain close together.

The source slit is the effective optical source. The spherical mirror re-images the slit near the optical head; the returned slit image defines the cutoff plane.

3.2 Source cone

At 3200 mm, the mirror subtends a half-angle of approximately:

$$\theta = \tan^{-1}(101.5/3200) \approx 1.82^\circ$$

The intended illumination cone is approximately $\pm 1.8^\circ$ to $\pm 2.0^\circ$, corresponding to approximately NA = 0.032–0.035 in air. Slight mirror overfill is preferred to underfill.

Useful nominal beam diameters for a $\pm 1.8^\circ$ cone are:

Distance from source slit	Approx. beam diameter
1 m	63 mm
2 m	127 mm
3.2 m	203 mm

The mirror's approximately f/7.9 focal ratio should not be confused with this source cone. The source operates near 2f, at approximately the mirror center of curvature.

3.3 Source/imager separation

The two rail pivot centers are separated by 95 mm at the mirror-facing front plate. At 3.2 m this gives approximately 1.70° total chief-ray separation.

Each rail points toward the mirror and follows its own chief ray. Sliding a fixture along a rail is therefore predominantly an axial adjustment.

The source slit and cutoff need not occupy exactly the same longitudinal coordinate. Near 2f,

$$\frac{ds_i}{ds_o} \approx -1$$

so small source-slit displacement produces approximately equal and opposite conjugate-image displacement.

A useful starting point is about 30–40 mm total slit/cutoff longitudinal staggering, obtained by placing them approximately ± 15 –20 mm around nominal 2f. This is an experimental setup adjustment rather than a fabrication-critical dimension.

3.4 Common optical-axis datum

The common optical axis is 72.35 mm above the top surface of the 2020 extrusion.

For optical-head CAD:

- take the rail top surface as $z = 0$;

- do not reference optical height to the tabletop or support feet;
- small whole-frame pitch/roll errors can be corrected at the mirror.

The optical head uses three coordinate frames with common senses:

- +y forward, toward the mirror;
- +x to the right when looking down from above with the mirror ahead;
- +z up, with the rail top at $z = 0$.

The frames are right-handed and differ only in where their y axes lie:

- pivot frame: y along the centerline of the front pivot plate, with the origin at the midpoint of its aft edge (§4.2);
- source rail frame: y along the source rail centerline;
- imaging rail frame: y along the imaging rail centerline.

The imaging rail is the right rail, at positive x in the pivot frame, and the source rail is the left. The phone extends well to the right of its camera axis when sighting along that axis toward the mirror (§9.1), so this places its overhang on the outer side of the imaging rail, clear of the source rail and its fixtures.

Each rail frame yaws with its rail, about 0.85° from the pivot frame at nominal (§4.2). Its origin is on the rail top at the rail's pivot axis; a fixture is described with its own rail station at $y = 0$. In a rail frame the optical axis is at $x = 0$, $z = 72.35$ mm, and pitch, yaw, and roll are rotations about x, z, and y respectively. A rotating fixture may define a local frame, stated where it is used.

The common post stack is:

- 0.010 in / 0.254 mm metal datum shim;
- 50 mm Thorlabs TR50/M post;
- 22.1 mm post-top-to-optical-axis offset for the SM1 optical holders (Thorlabs SMR1/M: 0.870 in / 22.098 mm exact);
- total nominal height: 72.35 mm (72.352 mm with the exact SMR1/M offset; the datum is 72.35 mm).

The datum discs are McMaster 2895T62, 3/4 in OD $\times$ 0.010 in ± 0.0005 in thick, full-hard 18-8 stainless steel, minimum Rockwell C40. Three discs are used as post datum shims, one under each common post fixture. The discs provide a consistent metal seating surface for the posts across the central slot in the 2020 rail.

4. Tabletop optical frame

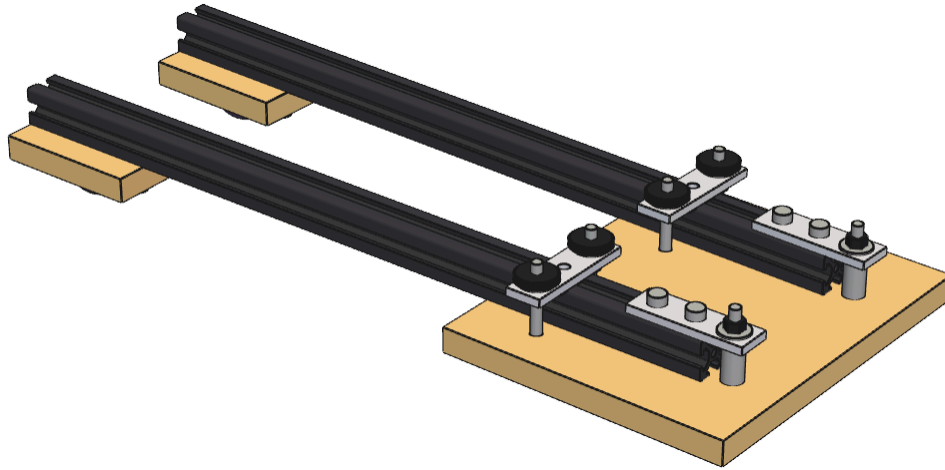


Fig. 1. Tabletop frame: rails, front pivot plate with pivot lugs and yaw straps, and rear foot blocks

The model is `src/schlieren/parts/frame.py`.

4.1 Rails

- IXGNUJ black-anodized metric 2020 extrusion, Amazon B08Y8N7FD1
- $20 \times 20 \times 400$ mm
- two rails used
- nominal 6 mm European-style slot

There is no rear crossrail.

Measured slot geometry of the extrusion:

Feature	Measured value
Slot mouth width	0.258 in / 6.55 mm
Internal cavity width	0.436 in / 11.07 mm
Slot depth	0.254 in / 6.45 mm
Lip thickness	0.065 in / 1.65 mm

These dimensions suit M5 hardware for 20-series / nominal slot-6 extrusion. Ordinary attachments use M5 $\times$ 0.8 socket-head hardware with flat washers in standard metric lengths and the roll-in/drop-in M5 T-nuts (Amazon B0DP6JBX4Y).

4.2 Front pivot plate

The front pivot plate is a $180 \times 150 \times 12.7$ mm Baltic-birch rectangle with no structural cutouts. The 180 mm dimension is transverse to the rails and the 150 mm dimension is fore/aft.

Plate coordinates are the pivot frame (§3.4): the origin is at the midpoint of the aft edge, +y runs toward the mirror along the plate centerline, and +x runs to the right seen from above with the mirror ahead. The mirror-facing edge is at $y = 150$ mm, and the left rail is the one at negative x. The pivot line is 25 mm behind the mirror-facing edge, giving pivot centers at:

- left pivot: (-47.50, 125.00) mm;
- right pivot: (+47.50, 125.00) mm;
- total pivot separation: 95 mm.

The nominal rail half-angle implied by the 95 mm pivot separation and approximately 3.2 m mirror distance is about 0.850° , or about 1.70° total chief-ray separation.

Each yaw-clamp station is 90 mm aft of its pivot along the nominal rail axis, giving yaw-strap centers at approximately:

- left strap center: (-48.84, 35.01) mm;
- right strap center: (+48.84, 35.01) mm.

Each fixed yaw strap is perpendicular to its rail at the nominal rail angle. The two outer holes of each 3-hole joining plate give fixed yaw-bolt centers at approximately:

- left outer: (-68.83, 35.31) mm;
- left inner: (-28.84, 34.71) mm;
- right inner: (+28.84, 34.71) mm;
- right outer: (+68.83, 35.31) mm.

Front pivot plate: drilling layout, seen from above

180 × 150 × 12.7 mm (1/2 in) Baltic birch. Six holes Ø5.5 mm through, for M5. Dimensions in mm: x from the plate centerline, y from the aft edge. Full scale when printed at 100%: check the plate width against a rule before using the sheet as a template.

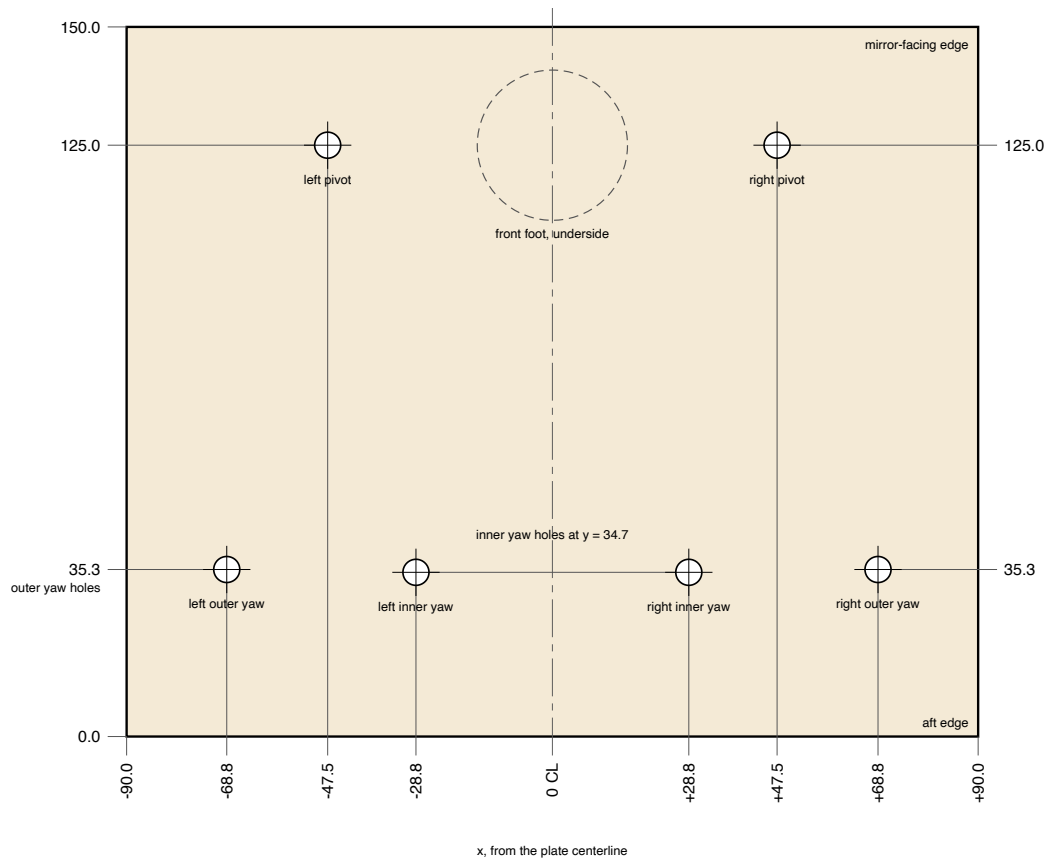


Fig. 2. Front pivot plate drilling layout, seen from above, in plate coordinates

The four fixed yaw bolts pass through approximately 5.5 mm round clearance holes; the plywood is not slotted. The straps stay fixed to the pivot plate while the 20 mm rails rotate beneath them. With 40 mm yaw-bolt spacing, the rail has approximately 7.5 mm nominal edge-to-M5-shank clearance per side and retains about 2.8 mm clearance at $\pm 3^\circ$ rail yaw from nominal for the 90 mm pivot-to-clamp distance. Rail-to-bolt contact does not occur until roughly $\pm 4.7^\circ$ from nominal, so the fixed-hole geometry provides ample adjustment range.

A front Sorbothane support foot is centered at approximately (0, 125) mm, directly between the two rail pivots, keeping the support point on the pivot line and clear of the pivot and yaw hardware.

1/2 in Baltic-birch sheet stock is shared across the tabletop frame and mirror cell: it supplies the front pivot plate, the two rear rail-support/foot blocks, the mirror-cell cell-adjuster plate, and the mirror-cell base plate.

4.3 Pivot and yaw hardware

Pivot and yaw hardware use commercially available 2020 three-hole joining plates:

- MOPFOL 2020 3-hole joining plate, Amazon B0G8DCS7VP
- approximately 60 × 18 × 4 mm
- 20 mm hole pitch
- four in all: two as pivot lugs and two as yaw straps.

Pivot stack

Per rail, from the bottom up:

socket head → oversized washer → plywood pivot plate → 20 mm spacer → 4 mm joining plate → oversized washer → M5 nyloc

The socket heads are beneath the plywood and the nylocs on top, matching the yaw-lock screws.

Hardware:

- McMaster 92290A265, M5 × 50 partially threaded 316 SS socket-head screw
- McMaster 92871A091, 20 mm × 10 mm OD × 5.3 mm ID stainless spacer
- McMaster 91116A350, M5 oversized washer, 15 mm OD
- McMaster 93625A225, M5 nylon-insert locknut

The pivot screws pass through approximately 5.5 mm clearance holes in the plywood.

Yaw lock

One 3-hole joining plate spans transversely across each rail. The two outer holes are used, giving 40 mm fixed bolt-center spacing. The strap is fixed to the plywood by two round-hole through-bolts, one on each side of the rail; the rail itself rotates beneath the strap. The plywood has no slotted yaw holes.

Each yaw screw stack, from the bottom up:

socket head → oversized washer → plywood pivot plate → (alongside the rail) → 4 mm yaw strap → oversized washer → M5 thumb nut

The thumb nuts are on top of the straps, where they are accessible with the frame standing on its feet.

A strip of McMaster 9852N37 adhesive-backed 1/32 in (0.79 mm) EPDM on the underside of each strap, where it bears on the rail top, adds friction to the yaw lock. The strip spans the strap width and stays between the bolt holes (about 30 mm long, clear of the holes at ±20 mm).

Each strap center is 90 mm aft of its rail pivot along the nominal rail axis, with the strap perpendicular to the nominal rail direction (§4.2). Yaw is adjusted and locked at the front pivot plate by loosening the two thumb nuts, rotating the rail beneath the fixed strap, and retightening. The bolt/rail clearance supports at least approximately ±3° adjustment about nominal with useful remaining clearance.

Hardware:

- McMaster 92290A265, M5 × 50 partially threaded 316 SS socket-head screws — same fastener as the rail pivots
- McMaster 91116A350 oversized M5 washers
- McMaster 92815A202 M5 low-profile knurled thumb nuts
- McMaster 9852N37 1/32 in EPDM friction strips, cut from the same sheet as the cassette clamp-bar pads

The yaw screws pass up alongside the 20 mm rail, not through it, and span the approximately 1/2 in (12.7 mm) Baltic-birch pivot plate, the full 20 mm rail height, the EPDM strip, the 4 mm yaw strap, washers, and the thumb-nut engagement. The M5 × 50 yaw-clamp screw deliberately reuses the pivot-screw part rather than introducing a separate low-profile screw.

4.4 Rear support and feet

Each rail has a removable 75 × 50 × 12.7 mm (3 × 2 × 1/2 in nominal) Baltic-birch rear foot block, cut from the same 1/2 in sheet stock used elsewhere in the frame and mirror cell. The 75 mm dimension runs along the rail and the 20 mm rail is centered across the 50 mm block width.

Each block attaches to the rail bottom slot with two M5 socket-head screws, two flat washers under each head, and roll-in/drop-in M5 T-nuts. The two screw holes lie on the rail centerline and are 50 mm apart, symmetrically placed about the block center; with the 75 mm block length, each screw center is 12.5 mm from its nearest end. The screws are M5 from the general M5 assortment, 20 mm long, through approximately 5.5 mm clearance holes in the plywood.

The two washers set the screw's depth in the slot. With two nominal 1.0 mm washers and the 12.7 mm block, a 20 mm screw enters the rail slot by about 5.3 mm, about 1.15 mm short of the 6.45 mm slot floor. A single washer leaves only about 0.15 mm, so the screw bottoms before the block clamps if the plywood runs thin; a 16 mm screw reaches only about 0.65 mm past the slot lip, too little to engage the T-nut; no standard length lies between.

Each rear-foot screw stack, from the bottom up:

socket head → two flat washers → plywood foot block → M5 T-nut in the rail bottom slot

A Sorbothane foot is centered on the underside of each block, directly beneath the rail centerline and midway between the two attachment screws. The 1-1/4 in / 31.75 mm diameter foot therefore does not obscure either attachment screw or washer, allowing the complete plywood/foot assembly to be removed from and reinstalled on the rail without disturbing the Sorbothane foot. The blocks and feet support the rear of each rail but do not provide yaw lock.

The complete frame is therefore supported on the table/bench top at three points:

- one centered foot beneath the front pivot plate;
- one foot beneath each rear support block.

Feet: McMaster 8215K2, 1-1/4 in OD × 5/8 in high, 30 OO Sorbothane, with a stiffer McMaster 8215K6 (same size) as an alternative depending on vibration isolation needs. Moderate static compression of the front foot is acceptable; the resulting small overall pitch is corrected during optical alignment.

5. Common rail-mounted post support

Three fixtures use the common post/shoe architecture:

1. light source (§6);
2. source-slit flexure head (§7);
3. cutoff carriage (§8).

5.1 Post

- Thorlabs TR50/M
- 12.7 mm diameter
- 50 mm long

5.2 Optical-holder allocation

- light source: 1 × SMR1/M (§6.1)
- slit head: 1 × SM1RC/M, clamping the printed spigot of the slit-head adapter (§7.6)
- cutoff carriage: 1 × SM1RC/M, clamping the printed spigot of the carriage base plate (§8.1)

The source/slit/cutoff holders preserve the 22.1 mm post-top-to-axis dimension.

5.3 Common rail shoe

The common shoe is a printed ABS U-shaped saddle that:

- straddles the 2020 extrusion;
- locks through the rail side channels with M5 screws into the measured slot geometry (§4.1), using the 20-series slot-6 T-nut hardware;
- leaves the rail top available as the datum surface;
- carries a vertical 12.7 mm through-bore for the TR50/M post.

The post passes through the printed shoe and bottoms on a McMaster 2895T62 0.010 in stainless datum disc resting on the rail top. The printed ABS does not establish the precision optical height.

The post bore incorporates a single-split clamping collar so that the post can be locked against rotational movement while remaining fully seated on the metal datum:

- one axial split;
- one transverse clamp screw;
- sufficient axial engagement to resist rocking and rotation;
- rounded stress-relief termination at the bottom of the split;
- generous fillets where the collar merges into the shoe body;
- free-fitting 12.7 mm post bore before clamping.

The clamp provides rotational and lateral retention; post height is still established solely by the post bottoming on the metal datum disc. The model, with its fit-tested ABS allowances, is `src/schlieren/parts/rail_shoe.py`.

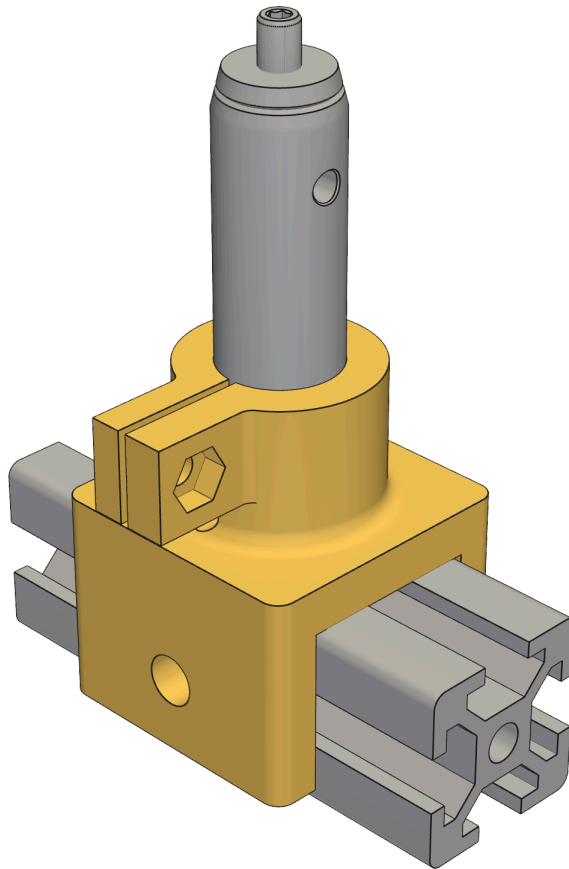


Fig. 3. Common rail shoe on rail with TR50/M post

Common printed split-clamp hardware

Every printed split clamp in the apparatus uses the same hardware:

M3 socket-head screw → clearance through one ear → captured M3 hex nut in the opposite ear.

- McMaster 91292A114 — M3 × 0.5 × 12 mm fully threaded 18-8 stainless socket-head screw; 5.5 mm head diameter, 3 mm head height, 2.5 mm hex drive. The same screw serves the carriage keeper frame (§8.4) and the slit head (§7).
- McMaster 91828A211 — full-height M3 × 0.5 18-8 stainless hex nut; 5.5 mm across flats × 2.4 mm high, DIN 934. The same nut serves the keeper frame, the cassette clamp bars (§8.7), and the slit head.
- No washer, nyloc, or threaded insert.

Ear thickness and the approximately 1–2 mm relaxed split gap are designed around the 12 mm screw length.

6. Light source

The light source is a single assembly on one TR50/M post and common rail shoe (§5): a Thorlabs SMR1/M holder that carries one of two interchangeable threaded LED modules on its rear face and a condensing lens and iris on its forward face. The condenser images the LED emitter onto the source slit (§7), and the iris sets the angular size of the illumination cone (§3.2).

6.1 Assembly and stack order

Parts:

- threaded LED module, green or white (§6.2)
- Thorlabs SMR1/M fixed threaded holder
- Thorlabs SM1V05 adjustable lens cell
- Thorlabs ACL2520U-A condenser
- Thorlabs SM1L03 tube
- Thorlabs SM1D12 adjustable iris
- Thorlabs SM1CP1 internally threaded protective cap
- Thorlabs SM1EC2 protective cap
- TR50/M post + common rail shoe

From the LED to the slit:

1. threaded LED module, its SM1CP2M cap threaded into the LED-side face of the SMR1/M;
2. SMR1/M on the TR50/M (0.400 in / 10.16 mm thick, SM1 thread through, no lip; 0.870 in / 22.10 mm post-top-to-axis offset);
3. SM1V05, its externally threaded sleeve entering the slit-side face of the SMR1/M and locked with the included SM1NT. The ACL2520U-A sits in the SM1V05 body with its plano face on the internal seat (toward the LED) and its convex face toward the open end;
4. SM1L03, threaded into the SM1V05 open end;
5. SM1D12, threaded into the SM1L03.

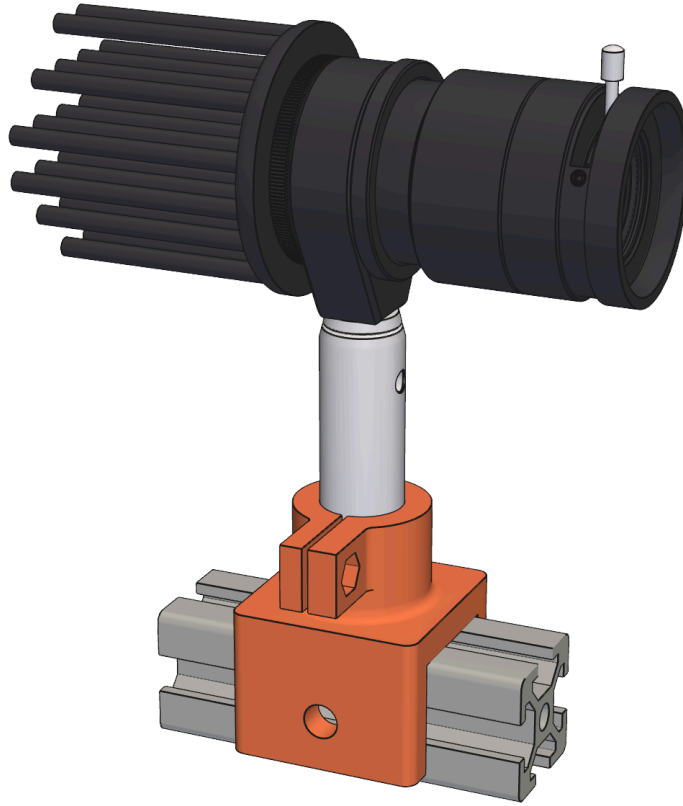


Fig. 4. Light source on rail: heatsink and LED module, SMR1/M, SM1V05, SM1L03, and iris

The ACL2520U-A convex vertex sits about 0.7 mm inside the SM1V05 open end, so the SM1L03 spacer is required ahead of the iris; the SM1D12 interferes with the lens if threaded directly into the SM1V05.

The cap and the SM1V05 sleeve share the SMR1/M thread. The cap threads in until its knurled flange seats on the SMR1/M face, so the LED position is fixed and the SM1V05 engagement is the focus adjustment (§6.7). Engagement runs from the Thorlabs minimum of 0.110 in / 2.79 mm to about 5.7–5.8 mm, where the sleeve end comes within 0.3 mm of the LED board. Turning the SM1V05 moves the lens, SM1L03, and iris together relative to the LED; the resulting few-millimeter iris shift is negligible against the 150 mm iris-to-slit spacing.

Thorlabs SM1 part dimensions in this stack-up (SMR1/M, SM1CP2M, SM1V05) are the exact inch-primary values from the vendor STEP models in `cad/vendor/`, not the rounded millimeter values on the drawings. The TR50/M is metric-primary and keeps its 50 mm / Ø12.7 mm nominals (its STEP model is rounded to inches).

`src/schlieren/parts/light_source.py` encodes the stack-up; `uv run light-source` prints the focus ranges.

6.2 LED modules

There are two interchangeable LED modules, each a self-contained threaded assembly. Each LED board mounts on an identical threaded SM1 carrier so that the SM1 thread and cap flange, rather than the individual MCPCB pattern, are the interchange standard.

	Green module	White module
Emitter	OSRAM OSLOM SSL 120, 530 nm nominal	Nichia 519A R9080, 5000 K
Board	NewEnergy star board, LST1-01F06-GRN1-00	Convoy 20 mm star/DTP carrier
Initial operating current	approximately 350 mA	approximately 500–700 mA

Module stack, from the rear toward the condenser:

1. Alpha CN40-40B heatsink (§6.3), bolted to the rear face of the cap with thermal compound between;
2. Thorlabs SM1CP2M externally SM1-threaded end cap (0.210 in / 5.33 mm solid aluminum, 0.100 in / 2.54 mm thread, Ø1.200 in / 30.48 mm knurled flange);
3. LED star board on the front face of the cap (§6.4).

Interfaces:

- The cap flange is the repeatable axial stop on the SMR1/M face; the module's rotational position at the stop does not matter.
- The SM1 thread centers the emitter on the condenser axis; no vertical calibration is required.
- Heatsink fastening: socket-head screws through the CN40 base in the open cells between pins, into blind M3 holes tapped about 2.5 mm deep in the cap rear face, with M3 × 6 mm screws (**provisional** length). Keep the rear holes angularly offset from the front M2 board holes (§6.4), since the cap is only 5.33 mm thick.
- Leads drop past the board edge through the board's edge slots, through a pair of holes drilled at about $r = 11$ mm through the cap (inside the thread root) and the heatsink base, and out between the pins.
- Fabrication is drilling and tapping of purchased aluminum parts only.

Clearances:

- The heatsink's lowest point is 2.1 mm above the TR50/M post top at any rotation (22.10 mm axis offset minus 20 mm maximum radius).
- The heatsink front face is 2.79 mm (0.110 in) behind the SMR1/M face (the cap flange thickness).
- The SMR1/M thread bore leaves about 3 mm of radial room around a 20 mm board for leads.

6.3 Common heatsink

- Alpha CN40-40B natural-convection pin-fin heatsink, one per module
- Ø40.0 mm (+0/−0.5) × 40 mm overall, 3.0 mm flat base, Ø2.8 mm pins on a 6.9 mm square grid
- 6063 aluminum, black anodized; 24.6 g
- manufacturer natural-convection rating 6.9 °C/W

At about 2 W (white module at 700 mA) the expected rise is roughly 14 °C above ambient; the green module dissipates about 1.1 W. The rating is the manufacturer's pins-up test; the module runs with pins horizontal, which pin fins tolerate well. **Provisional:** bench-test the temperature rise at 700 mA before relying on it.

The heatsink is round so that it clears the post at every rotation while the module is threaded in (§6.2); a larger or non-round heatsink would sweep its corners below the post top during threading.

6.4 LED board mounting

Measured star-board thicknesses (calipers):

- green NewEnergy star: 0.0625 in / 1.59 mm (the datasheet lists 0.047 or 0.067 in; the measured value governs)
- white Convoy 20 mm star: 0.0590 in / 1.50 mm

Both boards are about 20 mm across (NewEnergy 0.783 in / 19.9 mm, catalog).

Fastening standard:

- M2 × 0.4
- McMaster 92095A452, M2 × 5 mm screws

- tapped directly into the front (threaded) face of the SM1CP2M cap
- 1.6 mm tap drill
- M2 × 0.4 HSS tap

Use the cap's center-drill mark as the layout datum for the board hole pattern. Transfer each carrier board's hole geometry from the physical board rather than assuming it from the other module. Slightly oversized board holes permit final centering of the emitter on the cap axis: a 0.3 mm emitter offset moves the slit image about 2 mm, so center each board by watching its image on the slit blades before final tightening.

Add thin insulating washers beneath screw heads where necessary to keep the metal screw heads away from exposed board contacts:

- McMaster 91545A410
- M2 lubricant-filled nylon flat washer

A thin layer of thermal compound is used between board and cap.

6.5 Power and wiring

Power supply:

- ALIENTEK DP100
- use DC constant-current operation rather than PWM to avoid rolling-shutter banding

Connector standard:

- Micro-Fit 3.0
- 2-pin
- 18 AWG factory pigtails

Connector hardware:

- 2 × Molex 214758-1021, male-to-pigtail, 150 mm — module side
- 1 × Molex 214756-1023, female-to-pigtail, 600 mm — supply side
- 1 × Pomona 1825-02 red/black 4 mm banana-plug pair

The supply side should present recessed/socket contacts.

6.6 Condenser optics

The condenser images the LED emitter onto the source slit (about 6.6× magnification). Each slit point then sees the iris uniformly filled at the LED radiance, which gives a uniformly illuminated mirror. The LED image should cover the illuminated slit length; the domes enlarge the apparent emitters by about 1.4–1.5×.

Defocus in either direction underfills the $\pm 1.8^\circ$ cone: iris-edge rays then trace back beyond the emitter edge, darkening the mirror edge and shortening the uniformly lit slit length. With the LED at the condenser focus (12 mm, collimated) the emitter cannot fill the cone even at the slit center.

Using ACL2520U-A catalog values (EFL 20.1 mm, BFL 12.0 mm; object-side principal plane about 8.1 mm inside the plano face) and about 153 mm from the convex vertex to the slit, the optimum emitter-to-plano-face gap is about 15 mm. The optimum moves only about ± 0.7 mm for ± 30 mm of slit position.

6.7 Focus and module interchange

Setup values (not hard CAD dimensions):

- emitter-to-plano-face gap approximately 15 mm, measured to the emitting surface, not the dome top
- useful gap range roughly 13–17 mm
- condenser/iris-to-slit spacing approximately 150 mm
- initial iris opening approximately 9–10.5 mm (about ± 1.7 – 2.0° at 150 mm)

Set focus by imaging the LED onto the closed slit blades and turning the SM1V05 until the emitter image is sharp and centered, then lock the SM1NT and open the slit.

Calculated emitter heights above the cap face, using the measured board thicknesses, about 0.07 mm of solder, and the apparent emitter heights through the LED domes (calculated from the manufacturer outline drawings: OSLON about 0.45 mm, 519A about 0.75 mm), with the gap range each module reaches over the SM1V05 engagement range:

Module	Emitter height above cap face	Emitter-to-plano gap range	SM1V05 engagement at 15 mm gap
Green	about 2.1 mm	about 13.2–16.2 mm	about 3.9 mm
White	about 2.3 mm	about 12.9–16.0 mm	about 3.7 mm

The two modules focus about 0.2 mm apart in engagement, about one-third of a turn of the SM1 thread. An index mark per module on the SM1V05 is optional.

Focus margin about the 15.04 mm optimum gap is about 1.1 mm (long-gap side) and 1.8 mm (short-gap side) for the green module, and only about 0.93 mm and 2.1 mm for the white module. The white module's long-gap travel is limited by the SM1V05 minimum engagement. **Provisional:** the white module's reduced margin is to be confirmed on the build. If it cannot reach a sharp slit image, space its cap flange off the SMR1/M face with a thin shim (about 0.1 mm restores 1.0 mm of margin). The shim moves the whole module away from the lens and keeps the flange as the axial stop; a shim under the star board would instead shorten the gap and make the shortfall worse.

Module interchange:

1. disconnect the Micro-Fit lead;
2. unscrew the module (cap and heatsink together) from the SMR1/M, about four turns;
3. screw in the alternate module until its flange seats;
4. touch up focus on the closed slit blades if needed.

7. Source slit

The source slit is a flexure slit head: one flat-printed ABS part carrying both blades, with fine centering perpendicular to the slit and fine slit-width adjustment, mounted for continuous rotation about the optical axis in an SM1RC/M on the common post and rail shoe (§5).

The model is `src/schlieren/parts/slit_head.py` (`uv run slit-head`, with `--show` for the viewer assembly).

The slit needs only about ± 2 mm of centering travel, one adjustment axis, and discrete orientations, so it does not use the cutoff's carriage, plungers, guide rails, keeper frame, datum pins, or cassettes (§8).

Provisional: the flexure dimensions are first-print values, and the stage-rotation figures below come from a first-order flexure model, not FEA; both are to be confirmed on the assembled head (§7.7).

7.1 Blades and slit widths

The slit uses two Stanley 11-515 backed single-edge scraper blades.

Measured physical blade dimensions:

- length: 1.535 in / 38.99 mm
- width: 0.768 in / 19.51 mm
- thickness at the sharp/flat portion: 0.010 in / 0.254 mm
- thickness at the folded spine: 0.040 in / 1.016 mm

Expected operating slit widths are 0.10–0.30 mm, starting around 0.15–0.20 mm.

Each blade lies flat on its carrier's blade seat, cutting edge toward the slit and overhanging the carrier edge by about 1.5 mm. No blade pockets, holes, or spine compensation are used; a slight inclination of the blade toward its folded spine is acceptable, since the optically important geometry is the gap and parallelism of the two cutting edges.

7.2 Architecture

The head is a three-body monolithic flexure:

1. frame — fixed; carries the spigot adapter, the FAS100 #1 insert, and the spring seat;
2. platform — centering stage on a parallelogram flexure from the frame; carries the datum blade and the FAS100 #2 insert;
3. width stage — on a nested parallelogram flexure from the platform; carries the movable blade.

Both parallelograms translate perpendicular to the slit. Their parasitic motion (about δ^2/L) lies along the slit, where it is harmless.

Local frame, at rotation 0: slit horizontal, adjustment axis vertical, both FAS100 knobs up. The blade-seat plane (the carrier front faces) is the front of the head; every other front face stands back 1 mm so the overhanging blades cannot rub moving or fixed parts.

The head's front faces the light source, so the LED image on the blades is in plain view for centering and focus (§6.7). The spigot adapter, slip ring, and post are on the mirror side of the blades. In this section "front" and "back" refer to the head, not to the rail direction.

Envelope: about 80 × 88 × 13 mm, excluding knobs and adapter.

Stage rotation in the slit plane would skew the slit against the cutoff (centering) or open it in a taper (width). Under load each flexure blade bends into an S with its inflection at mid-span, so only a force through the blades' mid-span needs no axial reaction; the layout keeps the varying drive forces from twisting the stages:

- FAS100 #1 and the preload spring are coaxial and act on the platform's flexure connectors, so their forces cancel and only the small centering-flexure force is unbalanced;
- the two centering blades are at the top and bottom of the platform, about 63 mm apart;
- the two width-stage blades are 12 mm apart, and FAS100 #2 pushes on the width-stage connector.

Closely spaced blades or a spring offset from the screw would not achieve this: a compact layout with 5 mm blade spacing and the spring 23 mm from the screw gives a constant $\sim 1^\circ$ platform pre-twist and about 8 mrad of rotation over the centering travel.

7.3 Centering stage

- travel: ± 2.0 mm about the as-printed position;

- drive: Thorlabs FAS100 1/4"-80 adjuster, 0.3175 mm per turn (10 μ m per about 11° of knob), in a McMaster 98625A950 brass insert in the frame top bar;
- preload: McMaster 2006N292 spring, coaxial with FAS100 #1, 16.5 mm long at mid travel (9 mm compression), about 4.4–6.9 N over the travel; located by printed guide pins inside the coil in pockets in the frame bottom bar and the lower platform connector;
- flexure: two 0.8 mm ABS blades, 35.5 mm long, 12 mm deep; about 0.38% peak strain at full travel;
- estimated slit rotation: about 0.05 mrad over the full ± 2 mm (0.5 μ m across a 10 mm lit slit length).

Measured spring OD: 0.272 in / 6.91 mm (calipers). Spring pockets are $\varnothing 7.91$ mm (1.0 mm diametral clearance).

Spring installation: the pockets are closed on all sides except the 3.5 mm flexure gap, and the 16.5 mm cavity is shorter than the 25.5 mm free length, so the spring has no clear insertion path. It is installed by compressing it fully and working it into the pockets by hand. If that proves unreliable, the fallback is a bottom access bore through the frame bottom bar closed by a screwed cap carrying the lower guide pin (not modeled).

Sensitivity: the iris is about 150 mm before the slit, so moving the slit by d turns the illumination cone by $d/150$; at the mirror the beam moves about $21 \times d$. The ± 2 mm travel therefore steers the beam about ± 42 mm at the mirror, which covers printed-part and shoe tolerances plus deliberate aiming. For a horizontal slit this is the only vertical aiming adjustment at the source.

7.4 Width stage

- drive: a second FAS100 in a 98625A950 insert in the platform top bar; pushing closes the slit;
- preload: the stage's own flexures, printed so that FAS100 #2 always deflects them 0.8–1.6 mm (about 0.8–1.6 N, comfortably above the stage's own weight in any orientation);
- usable width adjustment: 0.8 mm;
- flexure: two 1.2 mm ABS blades, 45 mm long, 12 mm apart; about 0.29% peak strain;
- estimated taper: about 0.6 μ m across a 10 mm lit slit length per 0.1 mm of width change (about 4.6 μ m over the full 0.8 mm).

Only the movable blade moves, so a width change shifts the slit center by half the change. For a 0.1 mm change that is 0.05 mm, which moves the beam about 1 mm at the mirror and needs no recentering of the slit (the cutoff is readjusted for any width change in any case).

Slit setup:

1. with both clamp bars loose, set the width stage to mid travel with FAS100 #2;
2. clamp the datum blade on the platform carrier;
3. set the movable blade against a true-metric feeler gauge between the cutting edges, pressing gently along its length, and clamp it progressively;
4. remove the gauge; thereafter set width with FAS100 #2 from that reference (0.15 mm is about half a turn). Re-check parallelism with the gauge after large width changes.

7.5 Blade clamping

Each blade is pinched against its carrier by an identical removable printed ABS clamp bar (54 $\times$ 7 $\times$ 4 mm) faced with McMaster 9852N37 1/32 in EPDM. The bar bears on the flat portion of the blade about 3 mm back from the cutting edge, leaving the slit cone clear, and is fastened by two M3 $\times$ 12 mm socket-head screws just beyond the blade ends into M3 hex nuts captured in pockets opening from the carrier back. The common McMaster 91292A114 screw and 91828A211 nut are used; four of each.

7.6 Rotation mount and clearances

A separate printed spigot adapter is bolted to the frame back with four M3 × 12 mm socket-head screws, counterbored from the head front into M3 nuts captured in the adapter back. The adapter is a flat plate, held 1.0 mm off the moving stages by two McMaster 93475A210 M3 flat washers (0.4–0.6 mm each) stacked on each screw between frame and plate. It carries a hollow Ø30.48 mm (SM1 tube OD) spigot with a Ø24 mm light bore, clamped by the SM1RC/M split ring (Ø30.6 mm bore, 10.16 mm thick, M4 locking screw across the split).

A Ø34 mm shoulder on the spigot is the ring's axial stop: the ring seats against it, which places the adapter plate 3.5 mm in front of the ring face and 2.2 mm clear of the post at every rotation. Do not clamp the ring away from the shoulder.

The SM1RC/M keeps the 22.1 mm post-top-to-axis dimension (§5.2). Loosening the ring rotates the whole head about the optical axis:

- rotation 0: horizontal slit, vertical centering, knobs up;
- ±90°: vertical slit, horizontal centering, knobs sideways;
- small rotations: slit-to-cutoff parallelism trim.

Calculated clearances over –110° to +110°: at least 2.2 mm to the post body, 4.0 mm to the rail shoe (at about ±50°, as the corners pass). The TR50/M M4 stud reaches up into the ring's tapped hole and stops about 1.7 mm short of the spigot at its 5.2 mm drawing maximum; this gap is set by the Thorlabs parts, not by this design. Beyond about ±125° the adapter corners and knobs reach the shoe.

7.7 Fabrication and fit

Printed parts: the flexure head, the spigot adapter, and two clamp bars.

- Head: print back face down, so the blade seats on both carriers are the topmost layer and coplanar (ironing recommended); the flexure blades are then vertical walls loaded in the layer plane. Keep perimeter seams off the four flexure blades.
- Adapter: print front face down, spigot up; no supports.
- Clamp bars: print flat, EPDM face down.
- The insert bores are pilots, finished by a light hand ream with a 5/16 in twist drill to a press fit (§8.3); flanges outboard.
- The spigot is printed at the SM1 tube nominal.

Hardware: 2 × FAS100, 2 × 98625A950 inserts, 2 × N52 10 × 5 × 2 mm magnet bearing pads (one under each FAS100 ball tip, §8.3), 1 × 2006N292 spring, 8 × M3 × 12 mm socket-head screws, 8 × M3 nuts, 8 × M3 flat washers.

A test print of the head (Prusa MINI+, ABS) confirmed the insert press fit, the magnet, spring, and other pockets and bores as sized, and essentially parallel flexure motion along both push axes.

Provisional, pending assembly of the complete head:

- spigot fit in the SM1RC/M, and the blade clamp bars;
- width-stage preload holding the stage on its adjuster at the low end of travel;
- no stage contact with the adapter plate;
- blade-edge parallelism versus width setting, and slit rotation versus centering travel, measured against the first-order estimates;
- ABS creep of the flexures over days at a fixed setting.

8. Cutoff

The cutoff sits at the returned slit-image plane on the imaging rail. It is a rotating carriage (§8.1–8.5) holding interchangeable 64 mm cassettes (§8.6–8.7), which carry the cutoff element: a knife edge, a fine wire (§8.8), or a color filter (§8.9). The carriage model is `src/schlieren/parts/carriage.py`; the cassette blank and clamp bars are modeled in `src/schlieren/parts/cassette.py`.

8.1 Spigot and rotation interface

The carriage mounts in 1 × Thorlabs SM1RC/M through a hollow printed spigot integral with the carriage base plate, the same interface as the slit-head adapter (§7.6):

- Ø30.48 mm spigot (SM1 tube OD nominal), clamped directly by the SM1RC/M split ring (Ø30.7 mm bore, 10.16 mm thick, M4 locking screw across the split); the spigot end is flush with the ring's rear face;
- Ø24 mm light bore through the spigot, matching the plate aperture;
- Ø34 mm shoulder as the ring's axial stop: the ring seats against it, which places the plate back 12.0 mm in front of the ring face. Do not clamp the ring away from the shoulder.

The 12.0 mm ring gap is set by the rail shoe, not the post. At nominal zero the plate reaches about 63.5 mm below the optical axis, past the shoe top (about 52.4 mm below), so the plate back must clear the shoe end (15 mm from the post axis): calculated clearance 2.1 mm to the shoe and 10.7 mm to the post body, at every rotation. The shoulder clears the post top by 5.1 mm.

No SM1 tube, printed split clamp, retaining ring, or printed SM1 thread is used. The SM1RC/M provides the rotational bearing and lock: when loosened, the carriage rotates on its spigot. Nothing retains the spigot axially while the ring is loose, so support the carriage when rotating it.

Required carriage rotation:

- at least $\pm 90^\circ$
- preferably ± 100 – 120°

Define nominal zero as:

- cutoff line horizontal;
- fine-adjust translation vertical;
- fine adjuster pointing upward.

The cassette-loading side of the carriage faces the mirror, so cassettes are loaded and retracted from the forward side, away from the telephoto. The spigot, slip ring, and post are therefore aft of the base plate; the ring's rear face, 22.2 mm behind the plate back, is the rearmost part of the station on the optical axis and is what the telephoto front must clear.

Fore/aft optical positioning is done by moving the rail shoe.

Rotation envelope: the 2020 rail runs beneath the carriage at every rail position, 72.35 mm below the axis. The base plate, guide frame, and keeper are trimmed to a 70.35 mm radius about the optical axis (the rail top less 2 mm clearance). Only the outer plate corners are removed; the plate is otherwise 86 mm wide, widened to 94 mm at the side keeper-screw lugs (§8.4). Calculated from the CAD, the carriage with its FAS100 rotates clear of the rail over $\pm 150^\circ$; only the FAS100 knob reaches the rail, near ± 170 – 180° . Nothing projects below the plate at nominal zero (§8.5). **Provisional:** clearance to other equipment on the rail near the cutoff station is not yet checked.

8.2 Spigot print and fit

The carriage base plate is printed deck down with the spigot up, so the spigot and shoulder need no supports; the guide frame above the deck is a separate print (the base/frame split exists for this). The three datum-pin shanks (§8.4) lie outside the shoulder and are flush-cut on the plate back.

Provisional: the spigot is printed at the SM1 tube nominal; fit-test it in the SM1RC/M and adjust if needed.

8.3 Fine adjustment

The carriage uses:

- 1 × Thorlabs FAS100, 1/4 in-80 × 1.00 in
- 1 × McMaster 98625A950 brass 1/4 in-80 insert
- 1 × McMaster 2006N292 compression spring

Insert geometry is taken exactly from the McMaster-Carr 98625A950 drawing, not from a generic 1/4 in-80 insert model. The drawing gives: internal thread 1/4 in-80; body outside diameter 0.313 in (7.950 mm); overall axial length 0.313 in (7.950 mm); under-flange/body length 0.298 in (7.569 mm); flange outside diameter 0.352 in (8.941 mm); flange thickness 0.010 in (0.254 mm); specified drill-bit size 0.313 in (7.950 mm); and minimum material thickness 0.298 in (7.569 mm). The 0.352 in dimension is the flange OD, not the bore or insert-body OD.

The insert bore is nominally 0.313 in (7.950 mm), matching the drawing. The printed bore is a pilot, finished after printing with a 5/16 in (0.3125 in) drill rather than relying on FDM accuracy; on the slit head this gave a good press fit (§7.7). The 8.5 mm insert support exceeds the drawing's 0.298 in (7.569 mm) minimum material thickness, with about 3 mm of radial ABS around the insert body. The flange is on the adjuster/outboard side, unrecessed, so the axial reaction from the FAS100 seats it against the carriage.

FAS100 / insert travel envelope for CAD: the FAS100 uses a 1.000 in (25.4 mm) long 1/4 in-80 adjuster screw. The 80 TPI pitch gives 0.0125 in (0.3175 mm) axial motion per revolution. Using the insert's 0.313 in overall axial envelope as a conservative full-engagement allowance leaves approximately 0.687 in (17.45 mm) of theoretical screw motion. That is a geometric clearance estimate, not a published FAS100 travel specification. The carriage's working translation is ±5 mm / 10 mm total, leaving useful adjuster margin before either end stop.

The FAS100 ball tip does not bear directly on printed ABS. The driven plunger carries a small hard bearing insert made from a nickel-plated rectangular NdFeB magnet:

- Amazon B0DMCY4FN1
- N52 Bar Magnet - 10 mm L × 5 mm W × 2 mm H
- one magnet in the driven plunger

The magnet is used as a hard, wear-resistant plated bearing surface; its magnetic function is incidental. It sits in a close-fitting printed pocket with its rear face fully supported by ABS, with a small CA or epoxy tack for retention. The FAS100 ball contacts the broad plated face rather than bare ABS.

8.4 Cassette seating

Cassette motion is controlled by opposed plungers:

- fine adjuster on one side;
- spring-loaded plunger opposite;
- three fixed rear datum contacts on the carriage define the cassette optical plane;
- shallow cassette/plunger bevels generate axial seating force against the datum contacts.

The three rear datum contacts are McMaster 97936A109 brass escutcheon pins / decorative finishing nails, used head-first as small domed sliding contacts. Each pin is approximately 3/8 in long, with a 0.050 in (1.27 mm) smooth shank and 1/8 in (3.18 mm) domed head.

Mount each pin through a through-hole in the printed carriage with the domed brass head on the cassette side. The holes are modeled $\varnothing 1.75$ mm: the measured 0.050 in (1.27 mm) shank, plus the 0.38 mm diametral hole undersize measured on the first base-plate print (the $\varnothing 24$ mm aperture printed 0.930 in), plus 0.1 mm fit clearance. If a shank binds, finish the hole with a #54 (0.055 in) drill. The hole fit only locates the shank; the head sets the datum. Seat the underside of the head firmly against the carriage datum face so datum height is established mechanically rather than by adhesive thickness. Wick a small amount of CA around the shank from the back for retention, then flush-cut and dress the projecting shank at the back of the carriage. Keep CA out from beneath the head/contact surface.

The three pin heads form a broad triangular support pattern around the optical aperture. The cassette rear face is the sliding datum surface and provides unobstructed swept tracks over the three domed contacts throughout the fine-adjust travel. The pin coordinates, set in the carriage CAD, keep every datum contact out of the swept track of the cassette's rear M3 clamp-screw countersinks over the full travel, so the datum tracks stay on uninterrupted printed rear-face material at every cassette position.

The plunger bodies are constrained to the intended translation axis by ears/tabs riding in slotted guiding rails. The guide slots prevent unwanted lateral movement or rotation while permitting the required axial plunger travel.

The plungers need an assembly path into their guides: both longitudinal ends of the guide path are occupied, by the FAS100 adjuster support on one side and the spring end wall on the other. The guide tracks are therefore open from the cassette-loading side; the plungers drop into them, and a separate printed keeper frame closes only the guide-ear regions.

The keeper is a perimeter frame, not a solid lid: the central upper aperture must remain open for cassette insertion and removal. Its side members span the plunger guide tracks and retain the guide ears against upward escape while the printed track walls carry the lateral guidance loads. The frame may be locally scalloped or notched where the FAS100 adjuster axis intersects its envelope, provided the material directly over the swept guide-ear paths and the load paths to the fasteners remain intact. The keeper's spring-end member also carries the roof of the end-wall spring cup (§8.5).

Keeper retention is mechanical, with eight fasteners per carriage. Each is the existing common McMaster 91292A114 M3 $\times$ 0.5 $\times$ 12 mm socket-head screw with a McMaster 91828A211 full-height M3 $\times$ 0.5 hex nut (5.5 mm across flats $\times$ 2.4 mm high), captive in a hex pocket opening from the plate back. Screw heads and nuts bear directly on the ABS, without washers; tighten only to a light snug, since the joint needs little clamp and a firm hex-key torque can crush the bearing face.

- Four end screws, at (± 38.5 , -53) and (± 38.5 , $+52$) mm in the carriage frame (y along the travel, +y toward the FAS100). Each sits on solid fill closing its guide track from 1 mm beyond the outermost ear position to the plate end. The fill is also the plungers' end stop: 1 mm past full loading retraction for the spring plunger and past +5 mm travel for the driven plunger. These positions keep each nut pocket at least 1 mm inside the rotation envelope (§8.1).
- Four side screws, at (± 42 , ± 37) mm, beside the middle of each plunger's ear travel. Each sits in a $\varnothing 10$ mm round lug that widens the base, frame, and keeper locally to 94 mm, clipped at the guide-track wall.

The side screws carry the ear wedge reactions (below) into the frame close to where they arise. A first-order beam estimate, with each keeper side member simply supported between adjacent screws, gives at most about 0.1 mm of upward keeper deflection at the ears at the maximum-compression load. That is within the 0.25 mm free play between the ears and the keeper; with only the four end screws it would be about 2–3 mm. The keeper side members are 3.0 mm thick. **Provisional:** if a print shows too much lift, a keeper with 5.0 mm side members fits the same screws: its counterbores are deeper, so the head seat height is unchanged.

The screw heads sit in an approximately 0.5 mm-deep recess in the keeper, and the captive hex pockets are approximately 2.5 mm deep. This leaves approximately 1.5 mm of ABS above each nut pocket and gives nearly full use of the 12 mm screw length, with only slight nominal screw projection beyond the nut. The keeper seats on broad printed lands, so the fasteners clamp it against the carriage rather than suspending it between isolated points.

The vertical guide stack is: 4.0 mm carriage back plate; 2.0 mm rise from the plate front to the lower guide-ear running surface; 3.0 mm plunger guide ears in a 3.4 mm guide channel; and a 3.0 mm keeper frame.

Provisional: the guide-stack dimensions, keeper recess and nut-pocket depths, sliding fits, and datum-pin projection are first-print values, to be tuned from printed fit.

Use a very light film of plastic-safe lubricant on the ABS-on-ABS sliding interfaces, particularly the plunger ears/tabs in their guide slots and any other plunger sliding faces. The lubricant is McMaster 1418K51 clear silicone grease, NLGI 1. Smooth/dress the printed sliding surfaces first, apply only a trace amount, cycle the mechanism, and wipe away visible excess so the lubricant acts as a thin boundary film rather than a grease-packed slide. Keep lubricant away from CA/epoxy/RTV bonding surfaces and apply it only after nearby adhesive work is complete.

The plunger seating lips and the cassette edge bevels are 27.5° from the cassette plane, with a 1.25 mm bevel depth.

For keeper-frame sizing, McMaster lists the 2006N292 spring rate as 0.14 lbf/mm. At the 9 mm fiducial compression this corresponds to approximately 5.6 N of in-plane plunger force; at the 14 mm most-compressed end of normal travel it is approximately 8.7 N. A frictionless first-order wedge model at $25\text{--}30^\circ$ from the cassette plane gives approximately 9.7–12.0 N upward reaction per plunger at fiducial and approximately 15.1–18.7 N per plunger at maximum normal compression. These reactions are carried upward through the plunger ears into the keeper frame; about 20 N per plunger is the working-load scale before safety margin.

Provisional: the bevel angle and depth, and the seating-force estimate (which neglects sliding friction), are pending a cassette insertion, seating, and tilt trial.

8.5 Spring seating and retraction

The spring plunger is preloaded by the McMaster 2006N292 compression spring (§8.3), acting between the frame's spring end wall and the plunger's outboard face on an axis 7.5 mm above the plate back. No guide rod, retract handle, or penetration of the end wall is used; a guide rod through the end wall would project below the axis past the rail top at nominal zero.

Each spring end sits in a printed cup, 3 mm deep, sized to the measured 0.272 in (6.91 mm) coil OD plus 1.0 mm diametral clearance:

- one cup extends inboard from the end wall: its side walls are on the guide frame, and its roof is carried by the keeper's spring-end member, so the keeper closes over the spring end when installed;
- one cup extends outboard from the spring plunger;
- both cups are open toward the plate deck, which carries the coil. Their side walls and roofs locate the coil ends laterally and against escape toward the cassette-loading side. Both print with legs on the bed and the roof bridging the coil, without supports.

The spring's free length is about 4–4.6 times its mean coil diameter, and both ends sit on parallel faces because the plunger is guided. That is below the roughly 5.3 critical ratio for buckling with fixed ends, so the cups need only locate the ends rather than guide the full length. The spring itself does not guide the plunger; the slotted carriage guides constrain plunger translation and rotation.

The spring has a free length of approximately 25.5 mm. The carriage is designed around a 16.5 mm spring length at the fiducial / mid-travel cassette position, corresponding to approximately 9 mm spring compression from free length.

Normal supported plunger travel is ± 5 mm about the fiducial position, for 10 mm total working travel. The corresponding spring-length range is approximately:

- 21.5 mm at the least-compressed end of normal travel;
- 16.5 mm at fiducial / mid travel;
- 11.5 mm at the most-compressed end of normal travel.

Loading retraction is a further 6 mm from fiducial (10.5 mm spring length), leaving 4.5 mm between the cups. Any additional compression capacity is treated as design margin rather than normal commanded travel.

Retraction for cassette loading uses a thumb tab on the spring plunger's front face at its outboard end:

- 20 mm wide $\times$ 3 mm thick $\times$ 6 mm tall, centered between the guide ears and outside the cassette footprint;
- the thumb reaches over the cassette and pushes the tab's inner face outboard, at about 9 N at full retraction;
- 0.5 mm chamfers on the exposed edges; the spring-facing face is left square;
- a $\varnothing 1.6$ mm grip bead along the inner top edge, flush with the tab top, prevents finger slip.

The tab is kept low, close to the plane of the guide ears, so that pushing on it does not twist the plunger and jam the ears.

8.6 Common cassette standard

Cassette envelope:

- 64 $\times$ 64 $\times$ 5 mm ABS
- 24 mm diameter central clear aperture
- identical shallow bevels on all four perimeter edges
- insertable at 0 / 90 / 180 / 270°
- perimeter kept clear enough to use any opposing edge pair
- orientation/polarity indicated by markings rather than a mechanical key.

Cassettes load with the spring plunger retracted 6 mm beyond fiducial (§8.5).

Cassette variants, all built on the common blank:

1. single razor knife edge;
2. centered fine-wire or filament dark-field cutoff (§8.8);
3. striated / multicolor gel filter (§8.9);
4. dark-center color filter (§8.9).

The standard cassette blank carries one opposed pair of integral filament cleats on the front / non-datum face, rather than making cleats a special cassette variant: two cleats, one on each side of the 24 mm optical aperture, at (± 25 , 0) mm on an aperture centerline, outboard of the razor blades and clamp bars. The cleats are slightly conical, $\varnothing 3.5$ mm at the cassette face widening to $\varnothing 5$ mm toward the top and rising 3 mm, so filament tension drives fine wire or thread down against the cassette front face. The tops are rounded to avoid damaging fine wire. Route a filament in an S path, around opposite sides of the two cleats; the free span then crosses approximately through the aperture centerline. Small angular error from finite cleat diameter or wrapping is acceptable because the SM1RC/M rotates the complete tube/cassette assembly. This makes the same universal cassette blank usable for blade, filter, Photofoil, wire, and thread experiments while keeping the rear datum face unobstructed.

Provisional: cleat geometry is pending a wire-mounting trial.

8.7 Cassette clamp bars

These bars and their hardware are the clamping standard for the cassettes (§8.6); the slit head uses its own smaller bars (§7.5).

Common clamp bars:

- two identical printed rigid ABS bars fit each cassette;
- each bar uses two fasteners, one toward each end, so clamp force is distributed along the element;
- no holes are made through razor blades, filter material, or other optical elements;
- no blade-specific locating pocket or guide is required;
- McMaster 9852N37 adhesive-backed 1/32 in, 60A solid EPDM is applied to the removable clamp-bar face to provide compliance and friction;
- the bar bears primarily on the broad flat portion of a razor blade rather than relying on the folded spine for its clamp datum;
- the same clamp-bar geometry holds razor knife edges, Roscolux gel/filter material, Photofoil, and similar thin sheet cutoff elements.

Clamp-bar fastening is from the cassette rear/datum face toward the optical/front face so no screw ends or nuts can protrude from the sliding/datum surface. Fasteners are positioned outside the optical-element footprint where practical; the clamp bar spans and pinches the element against the cassette front face. At each fastener, use:

flush M3 countersunk flat-head screw → 5 mm cassette body → printed clamp bar → M3 flat washer → ordinary M3 hex nut

The M3 flat-head screw is seated fully flush or very slightly below the rear cassette face and retained in its countersink with a small CA tack using McMaster 1818A45 / Loctite 4061. The CA serves only to keep the screw captive and resist rotation while the front-side nut is adjusted; it is not relied upon as the structural clamp load path. The ordinary M3 nut remains exposed and accessible on the front of the clamp bar. Place the washer between the nut and printed bar. Do not use prevailing-torque/nyloc nuts or threadlocker here.

Cassette clamp-bar hardware

Component	McMaster part	Specification
Flat-head screw	92125A133	M3 × 0.5 × 14 mm, fully threaded 18-8 stainless, 90° countersunk head; 6 mm head diameter, 1.7 mm head height, 2 mm hex drive
Flat washer	93475A210	18-8 stainless, 3.2 mm ID × 7 mm OD × 0.4–0.6 mm thick; DIN 125 / ISO 7089
Ordinary full-height hex nut	91828A211	M3 × 0.5, 18-8 stainless, 5.5 mm across flats × 2.4 mm high; DIN 934 (the common split-clamp nut, §5.3)

The clamp bars are 4 mm printed ABS. The cassette blank has four Ø3.4 mm screw holes at (±27, ±12) mm with rear-entry 90° countersinks matched to the 92125A133 head (Ø6.2 mm at the face: 6 mm head plus 0.2 mm diametral allowance), and each bar end provides a washer bearing land at least 7.2 mm across. The screw head finishes flush with or slightly below the rear/datum face so it cannot contact the carriage datum pins or interfere with cassette sliding. The fasteners, bars, nuts, cleats, and projecting screw ends are clear of the 24 mm optical aperture and carriage interfaces. The holes and countersinks are features of the universal cassette blank, not blade-specific geometry.

Because the clamp fasteners do not pass through the optical element, the screw length is not sized from a blade-thickness stack. **Provisional:** the 14 mm screw length is pending a fit test of the first printed cassette/bar assembly, confirming full nut engagement, useful clamp travel for razor blades and thin filter/foil media, a flush or recessed rear head, and clearance over the plunger lips.

8.8 Fine wire

The dark-field filament set is enameled copper magnet wire in three readily available AWG sizes. The nominal diameters below are bare-conductor diameters; enamel makes the finished optical obstruction slightly larger.

Wire size	Nominal bare diameter	Approx. metric diameter	Experimental role
44 AWG magnet wire	0.0020 in	0.0508 mm	fine / high-sensitivity filament
34 AWG magnet wire	0.0063 in	0.160 mm	intermediate filament, near the expected slit-image width
30 AWG magnet wire	0.0100 in	0.255 mm	coarse filament for stronger gradients / deeper dark field

Exact finished outside diameter is not critical for the qualitative instrument.

The universal cassette cleat pair described in §8.6 is the quick-change mounting for these wires and for dark sewing thread or other fibers. Apply only modest tension, particularly to 44 AWG wire; the conical cleats seat the filament against the cassette face, and the S-wrap places the free span approximately on the aperture centerline.

8.9 Color-filter material

Filter material is cut from the Roscolux 3 × 6 in Designer Color Selector, which provides more useful material per color than very small swatches.

For color schlieren:

- use the white Nichia LED;
- lock camera white balance;
- lock exposure.

9. Camera and telephoto support

The camera and lens are chosen (§9.1–9.2). **Provisional:** their support, a lens pointer and a phone rest (§9.4–9.7), is a baseline concept with a mock-up model, still under refinement and not yet designed in detail; this is the main remaining custom mechanical design work (§11).

9.1 Camera

- Apple iPhone 17, base model, in intended protective case
- held in landscape, with the rear cameras toward the mirror and the camera end of the phone toward the optical axis
- the Main camera is used, at 1× (or its 2× crop). It is the lower of the two rear apertures with the phone in portrait, "rear camera 2" on Apple's drawing (docs/reference/Apple-iPhone-17.pdf); the upper aperture is the Ultra Wide, used only at 0.5×

- measured camera optical axis approximately 60.6 mm above the lower long edge, in the case
- measured Main camera axis approximately 1.350 in / 34.3 mm from the near short edge, in the case; the case shape makes this hard to measure accurately with calipers

Manufacturer dimensions of the bare phone, from the drawing:

- both rear cameras are 13.62 mm from the nearer long edge, on a line parallel to it, so the measured axis height applies to either aperture
- the Main camera is 31.34 mm from the top short edge, 17.72 mm beyond the Ultra Wide at 13.62 mm
- body 149.61 × 71.45 × 7.95 mm; the camera glass stands 3.45 mm above the back glass

The drawing and the two measurements agree. The cameras are 57.83 mm from the farther long edge of the bare phone, so the measured 60.6 mm implies a case wall of about 2.8 mm at that edge; the 31.34 mm and the measured 34.3 mm imply about 3.0 mm at the short edge (both calculated).

Initial recording modes:

- 4K/30 for normal work;
- 4K/60 for faster flow phenomena;
- SDR / HDR off as a stable starting point.

9.2 Telephoto

- iOgrapher proSnap 7×
- 17 mm mount
- approximately 37.0 mm diameter
- approximately 116.8 mm long
- measured mass approximately 215 g

Measured barrel sections, from the aft end forward:

Section	Length	Outside diameter
aft end	0.565 in / 14.4 mm	not measured
rear cylindrical barrel	1.300 in / 33.0 mm	1.457 in / 37.01 mm
long cylindrical barrel	2.25 in / 57.2 mm	1.459 in / 37.06 mm
focus ring	0.455 in / 11.6 mm	not measured
front lip	0.175 in / 4.4 mm	not measured

Both cylindrical sections are suitable for clamping, giving about 90 mm of clampable barrel from 14.4 mm to 104.5 mm from the aft end. The focus ring must stay clear. The measured sections sum to 4.745 in / 120.5 mm, about 3.7 mm more than the overall length listed above; the difference is not resolved.

The lens barrel, rather than the phone shell, is the preferred transverse optical datum because accurate lens centering minimizes vignetting.

9.3 Alignment requirements

The returned slit image at the cutoff is the aperture stop for the camera: every ray from the test region passes through it, then spreads again at the $\pm 1.82^\circ$ cone angle (§3.2). The values below are calculated, and are **provisional** where they rest on assumed values: a lens front about 42 mm behind the cutoff plane, a 10 mm lit slit

image, a Main-camera pupil of about 3.7 mm (6 mm focal length at f/1.6), and a telephoto clear aperture near 30 mm.

Quantity	Value
Beam cone at the lens front	about 2.7 mm diameter
Beam footprint at the lens front	about 2.7 × 12.7 mm
Slit image at the phone, reduced 7× by the lens	about 1.4 mm long
Frame at 1×, 4K 16:9, through the lens	about 9.9° × 6.1°
Mirror in the frame	3.6° of the 6.1° height

The resulting tolerances on the camera and lens as one body:

- centering on the beam: about ±8 mm along the slit direction and ±13 mm across it, before the reduced slit image leaves the phone pupil; the lens front aperture allows a similar margin;
- pitch: about ±1.2°, the spare frame height either side of the mirror;
- yaw: about ±3°.

Pointing is therefore the governing adjustment, and centering is forgiving. Image quality still favors centering well inside the vignetting limit.

9.4 Support concept

The phone and the lens threaded onto its case are one rigid body. The lens barrel is its datum (§9.2): the lens is held at two stations along its barrel, and the phone hangs from its lens mount. Two separate rail fixtures carry them:

- the lens pointer, specific to the lens, holds the barrel at both stations on four adjusting screws (§9.5);
- the phone rest, specific to the phone, supports the phone's lower edge at one point (§9.6). A different phone needs only this part redesigned.

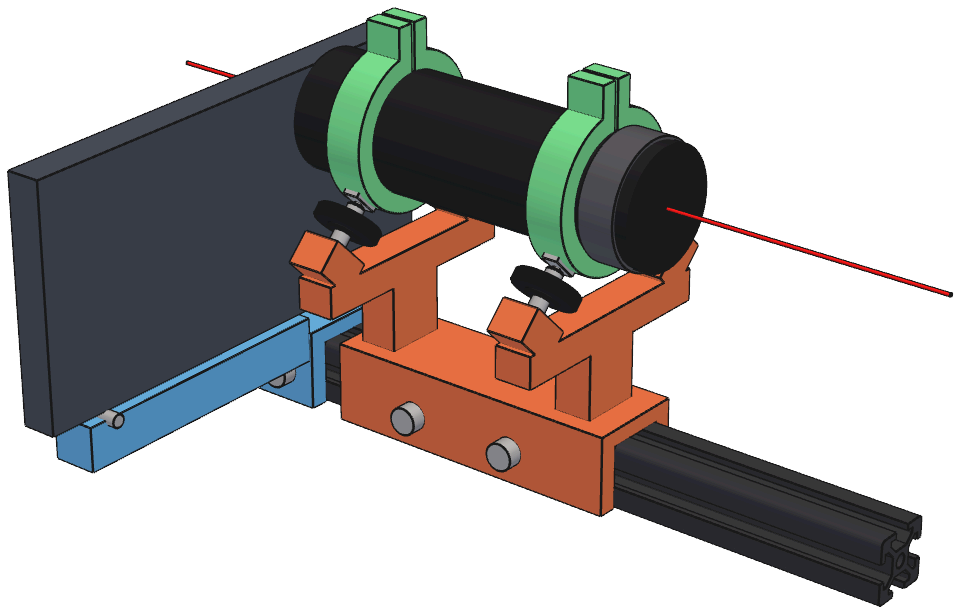


Fig. 5. Lens pointer and phone rest on the imaging rail, concept mock-up, with phone and lens envelopes

The body is located by six contacts and no more, so adjusting one station does not strain the lens mount:

- four screw tips, two at each station, fix the lens axis in x and z at both stations, and so its position, pitch, and yaw;
- one of those tips sits in a groove, fixing the lens fore/aft;
- the phone rest fixes roll.

Each station's pair of screws places one point of the lens axis, so the two stations give position and pointing without coupling between them beyond the lever ratio. Holding the lens, not the phone, takes the lens weight off the lens mount: the mount carries about 1 N in shear (calculated), against roughly 130–150 N·mm of bending if the lens were cantilevered from the phone.

The mock-up model is `src/schlieren/parts/camera_support.py`. It places the parts and checks their contacts and clearances with plain envelopes; fits, pockets, inserts, and print orientation are not designed.

9.5 Lens pointer

Two identical printed split collars clamp the barrel with the common M3 split-clamp hardware (§5.3):

- the aft collar on the rear cylindrical section, centered about 24 mm from the lens aft end, which leaves finger room for its thumb nuts ahead of the phone;
- the fore collar on the long cylindrical section, centered about 96.5 mm from the aft end, with its front face about 2 mm behind the focus ring;
- about 72.5 mm between them.

Each collar rests on two ball-tip screws (§9.7) at 45° either side of straight down, their axes meeting on the lens axis. The two yokes that hold the screws are one printed shoe straddling the rail and clamped through its side slots, so the camera slides along the rail as a unit. The collars are gravity-seated on the screws.

Each screw tip bears on a flat pad on the underside of its collar:

- three pads are the 10 × 5 × 2 mm magnets, set with the 10 mm side across the rail;
- the fourth, at the aft left screw, is a groove between two short pieces of rod stock lying across the rail. The ball sits between them, free to slide across the rail but not along it.

The two screws of a station are at right angles, so advancing one slides the collar across the other's pad by the same distance. Pad size, not screw travel, limits the adjustment. Calculated, keeping each ball 1 mm inside the pad edges:

Adjustment	Range
Each screw	about ± 3 mm
A station, in x or in z alone	about ± 4 mm
Lens tilt, pitch or yaw	about $\pm 2^\circ$
One turn of both screws of a station	about 1.1 mm, or about 0.9°

The tilt limit comes from the 5 mm side of the pads, on the pads that slide along the rail as the lens yaws about the groove. These ranges cover the alignment tolerances (§9.3) and the expected build errors.

Contact loads, calculated from the measured 215 g lens with an assumed balance point 60–70 mm from the aft end and an assumed cased phone mass of 177–210 g:

- aft screw pair: about 2.2–2.7 N;

- fore screw pair: about 0.6–0.9 N. The phone hangs behind the aft collar, so its weight pivots the lens about the aft screws and unloads the fore pair.

A hold-down of about 5 N at each collar, an elastic loop or light spring, is therefore required, the fore one most of all: without it a light touch, such as working the focus ring, unseats the fore collar. The alloy-steel screw tips are attracted to the magnet pads, which adds some preload; it is not relied upon until measured.

Provisional: the collar stations, pad arrangement and size, hold-down, and the pointer shoe are concept level. Larger pads would restore the full screw travel.

9.6 Phone rest

The phone hangs from the lens with its body to the outboard side of the optical axis (§3.4). Its weight, centered about 43 mm from the lens axis, would turn the lens in its collars. The phone rest stops that: the phone's lower long edge sits on one piece of rod stock lying along the rail, about 100 mm outboard of the axis, on the arm of a short printed shoe of its own.

- With the measured 60.6 mm camera-axis height, the phone's lower edge is about 11.75 mm above the rail top.
- The rest carries about 0.8–0.9 N (calculated, same assumptions as §9.5).
- The rest is fixed. Raising or lowering the aft collar rolls the phone slightly about the lens axis, which does not matter; the phone is not gripped and slides on the rod.
- The rest holds no optical alignment, so its dimensions are not critical.
- Because the rod lies along the rail, the rest needs to be only roughly under the phone.

Provisional: the rest geometry, a light retainer to keep the phone on the rod, and a loose safety catch against a knock are not yet designed.

9.7 Adjuster hardware

There are four adjusting screws, two under each collar. Each is a ball-tip set screw in a heat-set insert in its yoke, with a thumb nut threadlocked mid-screw as a handwheel.

Hardware:

- McMaster 93339A252, M5 × 0.8 × 25 mm ball-tip set screws: alloy steel, 25.0 mm overall including the ball, 2.5 mm hex socket, and a 3.0 mm ball (ball size from the vendor model, cad/vendor/McMaster-93339A252.step; drawing docs/reference/McMaster-93339A252.gif)
- McMaster 94459A797, M5 flanged heat-set inserts: 6.73 mm long overall, with a 7.92 mm flange 1.02 mm thick, a 7.11 mm knurled body, and a 6.32 mm pilot (drawing docs/reference/McMaster-94459A797.gif; vendor model cad/vendor/McMaster-94459A797.step). The drawing calls for a 6.40 mm hole and at least 6.48 mm of material. Each is set in its yoke boss from the lens-side face, flange outward, so the screw's reaction presses it into its hole
- McMaster 92815A202, M5 thumb nuts used as threadlocked mid-screw handwheels
- Loctite 271, McMaster 91458A160
- heat-set installation tip 92160A327;
- Amazon B0DMCY4FN1, N52 Bar Magnet - 10 mm L × 5 mm W × 2 mm H, as hard plated bearing pads, one at each of three screws;
- stainless rod stock, Amazon B08N4TSNPW assortment, for the two groove rods at the fourth screw and for the phone rest rod.

10. Mirror cell

10.1 Plates and basic architecture

The mirror-cell plywood thicknesses and plate envelopes are:

- cell-adjuster plate: 11.5 in wide × 11.0 in high × 1/2 in Baltic birch;
- base plate: 11.5 in wide × 11.0 in front-to-back × 1/2 in Baltic birch;
- moving mirror plate: 3/4 in Baltic birch, cut to the truncated-hex geometry below.

The fixed cell-adjuster plate and the base plate therefore begin as identical 11.5 × 11.0 × 1/2 in rectangular blanks. The cell-adjuster plate carries the three fine-adjustment stations. The base plate provides the structural/tripod-support base and is joined to the cell-adjuster plate by the structural brackets described in §10.7. The 3/4 in moving mirror plate carries the 203 mm mirror and moves relative to the fixed cell-adjuster plate.

The cell-adjuster plate is centered left/right on the 11.5 in-wide base. The rear face of the 1/2 in fixed cell-adjuster plate is 4.000 in / 101.6 mm aft of the front edge of the 11.0 in-deep base. The two McMaster 8681N11 structural angle brackets face forward, toward the moving mirror plate; their measured forward footprint is approximately 3.5 in from the fixed-plate rear face, leaving approximately 0.5 in of base margin at the front edge. This orientation places the brackets on the mirror side of the fixed plate so they directly resist the forward overturning moment of the mirror assembly.

Using measured masses of 1.56 kg for the approximately 18 mm-thick mirror, 840 g for the assembled fixed + moving plates and adjuster hardware, 500 g for the 11.5 × 11.0 × 1/2 in base plate, and 79 g each for the two aluminum brackets, the estimated completed mirror-cell fore/aft center of gravity is approximately 3.35 in / 85.1 mm aft of the front edge of the base. A working uncertainty of approximately ±0.2 in / ±5 mm is conservative. This places the expected center of gravity approximately 0.65 in / 16.5 mm forward of the rear face of the fixed cell-adjuster plate. The 130 g CAMVATE removable quick-release plate has little effect when mounted with its mass centered reasonably near this location; final balance is trimmed using the quick-release system's generous fore/aft sliding travel.

The cell uses:

- three fine-adjustment stations arranged at 120° intervals;
- compression-spring preload at each station;
- spherical washer interfaces for angular accommodation and gravity-load transfer;
- tripod interface through the CAMVATE 577/501/504-style quick-release system and the Sunwayfoto LB-68R leveling base.

The moving mirror plate geometry is:

- start from a regular hexagon 11.000 in / 279.4 mm vertex-to-vertex, oriented with one vertex upward;
- the corresponding normal flat radius / apothem is 4.7631 in / 120.98 mm;
- three alternating vertices lie on the three 120° adjuster axes, with the top vertex occupied by one adjuster axis and the two lower-side occupied vertices by the other two;
- the three adjuster-hole centers lie on a 4.750 in / 120.65 mm radius from the mirror center;
- the mirror aperture is 8-1/8 in / 206.38 mm diameter, providing approximately 1/16 in radial clearance around the nominal 203 mm mirror;
- clip the unused bottom hex vertex with a horizontal chord whose midpoint is 4.7631 in / 120.98 mm below the mirror center, matching the original hex apothem. This removes approximately 0.7369 in / 18.72 mm of the original lower tip and produces a new lower edge approximately 2.553 in / 64.8 mm long;

- the resulting trimmed moving-plate height is approximately 10.263 in / 260.7 mm from the new lower edge to the top vertex.

The nominal clearance from the bottom trimmed edge of the moving mirror plate to the top surface of the base plate is 3/8 in / 9.53 mm. This places the mirror center approximately 5.138 in / 130.51 mm above the base top. The top moving-plate vertex then lies approximately 10.638 in / 270.21 mm above the base top, leaving approximately 0.362 in / 9.2 mm of fixed-plate height above it within the 11.0 in-high cell-adjuster plate.

This truncated-hex geometry preserves the same approximately 0.701 in / 17.8 mm radial plywood width between the 8-1/8 in mirror aperture and the new bottom edge as exists between the aperture and each original hex flat. It therefore improves base clearance without introducing a uniquely narrow section.

The moving mirror plate uses 3/4 in Baltic-birch sheet. The 1/2 in Baltic-birch stock is shared with the tabletop frame and is used for the cell-adjuster plate, base plate, front pivot plate, and rear rail-support/foot blocks.

10.2 Three adjuster stations

There are three equivalent adjuster stations.

The adjusters are Kozak parts:

- TS250-80-2500 1/4 in-80 adjuster
- TB250-80-625 bushing
- KB250-80 adjustment knob

Use one adjuster, one bushing, and one knob at each of the three stations.

Each adjuster station includes a concentric compression spring.

The adjuster bolt passes through the spring and therefore positively retains and laterally locates it. There is no separate spring pocket or spring bore in the plywood.

Adjuster-bushing mounting

Each Kozak TB250-80-625 bushing is bonded directly into the 3/4 in moving mirror plate. No separate metal bushing carrier is used.

Mounting details:

- the bushing's narrow flange is on the mirror-facing / outboard face of the moving mirror plate, opposite the inter-plate spring space; spring/adjuster load therefore tends to seat the flange against the plywood rather than pull it away;
- drill the bushing bore 8.0 mm through the Baltic birch, preferably in a drill press with a sharp brad-point bit and sacrificial backing to minimize breakout;
- the 0.625 in-long bushing barrel is fully contained within the 3/4 in plate and is bonded over its available cylindrical length;
- use WEST SYSTEM G/flex 650 epoxy for the wood-to-metal structural bond;
- bond directly to clean, fresh Baltic-birch bore surfaces; do not CA-harden or pre-seal the bushing bore;
- degrease and lightly abrade the outside of the bushing barrel before bonding without materially reducing its diameter;
- wet both the bore and bushing barrel with a thin continuous epoxy film, while keeping epoxy out of the internal 1/4 in-80 thread;
- seat the flange fully against the outboard face, remove squeeze-out from both faces, and cure with the bushing axis held square to the plate;

- the thin bushing flange is treated primarily as a seating/depth-stop feature. Structural retention is provided by the full-barrel epoxy bond and cylindrical bearing of the bushing in the plywood.

This arrangement adds no hardware thickness to the inter-plate gap.

10.3 Compression springs and seat washers

Components:

- McMaster 2022N186 compression springs
- McMaster 98017A199 stainless spring-seat washers

Each of the three springs is captured between two seat washers, producing:

- 3 springs
- 6 spring-seat washers
- 6 shallow spring-seat-washer counterbores

The counterbores register the washers; they are not spring pockets.

The nominal wood-face-to-wood-face interplate gap is 0.500 in / 12.7 mm at the neutral mirror position.

The spring-seat washer counterbores are:

- diameter: 5/8 in (Forstner cutter);
- nominal depth: 1/32 in / 0.03125 in / 0.794 mm;
- use the same nominal depth for all three seats in the moving mirror plate and all three corresponding seats in the fixed cell-adjuster plate.

The McMaster 98017A199 washers are approximately 0.028–0.036 in thick, so the 1/32 in recess places them approximately flush with the plywood surfaces across their thickness tolerance. With the 0.750 in-free-length McMaster 2022N186 springs and the 0.500 in nominal interplate gap, the springs operate at approximately 0.250 in nominal compression before small washer-thickness and adjustment-position variations.

10.4 Spherical washer interfaces

Each of the three adjuster locations uses:

- McMaster 91131A028 spherical washer set
- one shallow close-fitting plywood socket/counterbore.

Total:

- 3 spherical-washer counterbores

These sockets participate in the mirror-cell gravity load path. The washer OD bears against the counterbore wall, transferring gravity load from the 3/4 in moving mirror plate/adjuster assembly to the fixed 1/2 in cell-adjuster plate.

Target depth:

- approximately 1/16 in / 1.6 mm

The diameter should be a close free fit, not a loose retention pocket. Final cutter diameter should be selected against measured washer OD rather than assuming a nominal oversize woodworking dimension.

Stationary-plate adjuster through-hole

At each adjuster station, use a 1/8 in / 3.175 mm initial alignment guide hole through the fixed 1/2 in cell-adjuster plate. This guide hole establishes a common center for the spring-seat counterbore on the mirror-facing face, the spherical-washer socket on the rear face, and the final adjuster clearance hole.

After machining both counterbores, enlarge the guide hole to a final 5/16 in / 0.3125 in / 7.94 mm through-hole. This is intentionally oversized relative to the 1/4 in Kozak TS250-80-2500 adjuster so the plywood does not become the angular bearing as the moving mirror plate tilts. A 5/16 in hole provides 0.03125 in radial clearance around a 0.250 in adjuster. Across a conservative full 0.500 in plate thickness, a 3° adjuster-axis tilt produces approximately 0.0262 in lateral displacement ($0.500 \times \tan 3^\circ$), so the clearance accommodates approximately the full $\pm 3^\circ$ angular capability of the McMaster 91131A028 spherical-washer interface. The actual effective constraining thickness is somewhat less because of the shallow counterbores.

The machining sequence is: 1/8 in alignment guide hole → shallow counterbores from both faces → 5/16 in final through-hole. The spherical washer, rather than the plywood through-hole, remains the intended angular bearing and load-transfer interface.

CA conditioning

After machining each spherical-washer socket:

1. wick a small amount of McMaster 1818A45 / Loctite 4061 low-viscosity CA into the exposed Baltic-birch fibers;
2. allow it to cure fully;
3. lightly dress the socket back to the required free fit.

The CA hardens the wood; it is not used to glue the washer in place.

Spherical-interface lubrication

Apply a very thin film of light grease only to the mating concave/convex spherical bearing surfaces of each McMaster 91131A028 washer set. Work the pair through its angular range and wipe away excess. This reduces friction and stick-slip as the mirror plate tilts during fine adjustment.

Keep the outside diameter and lower/load-transfer surfaces dry so the lower washer half continues to bear directly against the close-fit CA-hardened plywood counterbore. Keep grease away from plywood, adhesive-bonding areas, and RTV bonding surfaces. The grease is Lucas Oil Products NLGI #2 white lithium grease from shop stock.

10.5 Mirror mounting

The 203 mm mirror is carried within the 3/4 in moving mirror-plate aperture.

Six DOWSIL 737 RTV pads are placed radially between:

- the plywood aperture inner surface; and
- the mirror's outer glass edge.

These are compliant radial support/bond pads. Nominal pad geometry is approximately 18 mm circumferential length $\times$ 7 mm axial depth $\times$ the full approximately 1.7 mm radial bond-line thickness. Place the six pads at 60° intervals. Maintain the approximately 1.7 mm radial gap during cure with temporary non-stick centering shims positioned between pads; do not squeeze the mirror against the plywood or use the RTV pads themselves to force centering. The pad dimensions are practical build targets rather than precision-machined features. No counterbores or pockets are specified for the RTV pads.

Provisional: test adhesion to properly prepared Baltic birch before bonding, to decide whether an adhesion primer is necessary.

10.6 RTV glue-up cure surface

For mirror-plate glue-up and bench-top cure, use a non-stick polyethylene-family release surface beneath the assembly.

- approximately 12 × 12 in UHMW sheet
- large enough for the moving mirror plate (about 279 × 261 mm)
- flat, clean, dry
- no release spray required

This protects the workbench from accidental RTV creep or squeeze-out.

The release sheet is a shop supply rather than part of the finished instrument.

10.7 Structural brackets

Hardware joining the 1/2 in cell-adjuster plate to the 1/2 in base plate:

- 2 × McMaster 8681N11 3 in-long aluminum corner brackets;
- 6 × McMaster 90585A997, 5/16 in-18 × 1-3/8 in 316 SS 82° flat-head hex-drive screws;
- 6 × McMaster 90099A030 5/16 in-18 18-8 stainless heavy-profile nylon-insert locknuts;
- 6 × McMaster 96659A134 5/16 in stainless washers.

Each bracket uses a three-fastener pattern to avoid interference between perpendicular fastener stacks near the bracket's inside corner:

- two fasteners through the vertical cell-adjuster plate leg;
- one fastener through the horizontal base-plate leg;
- six installed structural fasteners total across the two brackets.

The bracket holes nearest the inside corner are only about 0.5 in from the corner. Do not populate opposing near-corner holes on both bracket legs if the resulting nut/washer stacks would intersect. Choose the single horizontal/base fastener position so it clears the two vertical fasteners and their hardware.

The 1-3/8 in screw length suits the approximately 1/2 in plywood + 1/4 in bracket + washer + heavy nyloc stack. With these washers and nuts, expected thread projection beyond the nut is approximately 0.11–0.14 in, or about 2–2.5 threads, preserving full locknut engagement without excessive overhang at the inside corner.

The bracket attachments are through-bolted rather than relying on wood screws.

10.8 Mirror safety and transport retention

Front safety retention is intentionally non-stressing:

- loose retainers/fingers prevent escape of the mirror;
- they apply no deliberate optical preload;
- any surface that could touch glass should be soft/non-marring.

A removable travel cover with standoffs is useful for transport.

Provisional: the safety retainers and travel cover are not yet designed.

10.9 Tripod interface

The mirror cell mounts on the tripod through a CAMVATE Manfrotto-type quick-release assembly with sliding plate (Amazon B0B2WBC921) on a Sunwayfoto LB-68R leveling base, whose top mounting stud is 3/8 in-16. The receiver stays on the LB-68R; the removable 501PL/577/504-compatible sliding plate stays attached to the underside of the 1/2 in Baltic-birch mirror-cell base.

The sliding plate is 7.00 in / 177.8 mm long, mounted with its forward end flush with the front edge of the 11.0 in-deep base, so it spans 0–7.00 in / 0–177.8 mm aft of the front edge and its geometric center lies 3.50 in / 88.9 mm aft of that edge. This is only 0.15 in / 3.8 mm aft of the estimated mirror-cell center of gravity (§10.1), negligible relative to the CoG uncertainty and the quick-release system's sliding adjustment.

The plate is attached by four McMaster 92125A196 M4 × 0.7 × 18 mm 90° flat-head screws:

flush flat-head M4 screw → countersunk 1/2 in Baltic-birch base → M4 × 0.7 tapped hole in solid aluminum of the sliding plate.

The screws are in a two-front / two-rear rectangular pattern. Each screw center is 1.875 in / 47.625 mm in from its nearest longitudinal plate end, and the two screws at each longitudinal station are ±0.500 in / ±12.7 mm from the plate centerline. The longitudinal stations are therefore 1.875 in and 5.125 in / 47.625 mm and 130.175 mm aft of the base front edge, with 1.000 in / 25.4 mm transverse spacing within each pair and 3.250 in / 82.55 mm between pairs. These locations lie in solid aluminum, clear of the sliding/clamping bearing surfaces and the central camera-screw slot. The heads finish flush with or slightly below the plywood top surface. The holes are tapped with an M4 × 0.7 tap (3.3 mm tap drill), and the screws are retained with Loctite 243 medium-strength removable threadlocker.

11. Provisional areas and next steps

Procurement state and the CAD state of printed parts are tracked in bom/bom.csv.

11.1 Provisional areas

Design areas marked **Provisional** in the sections above:

- **Light source** (§6.2, §6.3, §6.7): M3 heatsink-screw length; heatsink temperature rise at 700 mA; white-module long-gap focus margin.
- **Source-slit head** (§7): flexure dimensions and stage-rotation estimates; spigot and clamp-bar fit; width-stage preload; adapter-plate clearance; slit parallelism and rotation; flexure creep.
- **Cutoff carriage** (§8): spigot fit in the SM1RC/M; guide-stack, recess, and pocket dimensions, sliding fits, and datum-pin projection; keeper lift under the ear wedge reactions; bevel angle and seating force; clearance to other equipment near the cutoff station.
- **Cassettes** (§8.6, §8.7): filament-cleat geometry; clamp-bar screw length.
- **Lens pointer and phone rest** (§9): the main remaining custom design, a baseline concept with a mock-up model. Open points include the collar clamp and pad pockets, pad size, the hold-down at each collar, the yoke and shoe detail and its rail clamping, the phone rest geometry with a retainer and safety catch, the fitting and removal sequence, and packaging beside the cutoff station. The alignment tolerances rest on assumed lens and camera values, and the contact loads on an assumed lens balance point and phone mass.
- **Mirror cell** (§10.5, §10.8): RTV adhesion primer decision; safety retainers and travel cover.

11.2 Next steps

1. Fit-test the printed parts: the assembled slit head (§7.7); the cutoff carriage and a cassette blank (§8), including datum-pin seating, bevel seating, keeper lift, and clamp-bar screw length.

2. Fabricate both threaded LED modules: drill and tap the caps and heatsinks, center each board, and set focus on the slit blades. Confirm that the white module reaches focus; if not, add a thin cap-flange shim (§6.7). Bench-test the heatsink temperature rise.
3. Design the lens pointer and phone rest in detail (§9), after measuring the magnet pull on a screw tip, the lens balance point, and the cased phone mass.
4. Design the mirror-cell safety retainers and travel cover (§10.8).
5. Assemble the tabletop optical head.
6. Perform a dry optical layout near 3.2 m before making any remaining irreversible holes or bonds.
7. Bond the mirror into the moving plate (§10.5) at the destination, after a dry fit and an adhesion test. The cell is otherwise assembled; the mirror travels separately, protected, because there is not enough cure time before departure.